



Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

Reason, Debate and a Story

Reason, Debate and a Story

Jukti Takko Aar Gappo

Director: Ritwik Ghatak

Production Company: Rit Chitra

Executive Producer: Ritwik Ghatak

Written by: Ritwik Ghatak

Director of Photography: Baby Islam

Editor: Amalesh Sikdar

Music: Ritwik Ghatak

Cast:

Ritwik Ghatak

Tripti Mitra

Shaoli Mitra

Utpal Dutt

Bijon Bhattacharya

Gyanesh Mukherjee

India 1974

120 mins

Digital 4K (restoration)

The screening on Wed 3 Jun will be introduced by season curator Sanghita Sen

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Jukti Takko Aar Gappo (*Reason, Debate and a Story*) was officially dated a year later than *A River Called Titas* (1973) but in fact started before that project. It was specifically the story of a group of young men involved in an ever more futile armed struggle against the state, and there is little doubt that it was a comment on the Naxalite cause by which Ghatak had been both attracted and repelled. Essentially, however, it was his own autobiography, with the drunken intellectual – who in the end confronts the Naxalites – played by himself. ‘This will be my most serious and my most complex film,’ Ghatak had said beforehand and there is little doubt that it makes a fascinating epitaph. His own performance is certainly a revelation.

Kumar Shahani has written that Ghatak was chronically short of funds and vomiting blood when he made the film, yet his portrayal of the drunken man was ‘unparalleled’. ‘I remember him on the days when he stalked down the Institute corridors and we addressed him as the Tiger from Blake’s poem which he loved to quote. In *Jukti Takko Aar Gappo*, he seemed to remember it too – only with a change of meaning: “I am burning, everyone is burning, the universe is burning.” Shahani notes the scenes of confrontation with his wife, the young woman from Bangladesh and the Naxalites, and the individual shot where he sits against the light falling from his window, the face emerging from the washed-out area almost as that of a ghost. ‘In Indian cinema,’ he writes, ‘the only other performance of such great simplicity and directness that I know is that of the saint-poet Tukaram (in the film of the same name) played by Pagnis.

‘The saint was also considered a deviant in his own time. Is it a commentary on our society – perhaps in the vein of Ritwik himself – that modern saints should be so driven to alcoholism and suchlike that they are emasculated before they can make a lasting impact? Tukaram has lived through his songs and the legends about him amongst the people of Maharashtra. He made a permanent dent in the rigid caste structure. In his own way, Ritwik must have hoped to make a change. In all the 15 years that I knew him every crisis brought to him a sense of euphoria. The communist uprising of his youth had taught him renewed vigour and hope. But like most other poets he had not the ability to organise. He chose instead to sing.’

Ghatak died two years after the completion of his last film. At 51 he had lived enough for two men, but frequently self-destructively. His body was taken to the crematorium in an open public vehicle so that his many friends could see him. It was, a witness has commented, like a scene from one of his own films. Perhaps the way *Jukti Takko Aar Gappo* should have ended. He had certainly summed up his own tragedy in the film within the lines: ‘For a bottle I will lie and steal but for name or fame or position I will never lie.’ To which a young man replies: ‘You have practised that pose long enough to become an adept.’ Yet his justification remains in the small group of films which can be accounted among the most lively, committed and passionate to be made in postwar India. ‘I have no right,’ he once said, ‘to indulge in art unless I am able to bring into sharp focus at least one facet of the acute crisis facing our country. Most of my films are humble efforts to come to grips with that.’

Derek Malcolm, *Sight and Sound*, Summer 1982

Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

The Citizen Nagarik

Mon 1 Jun 20:35; Fri 26 Jun 18:05 (+ intro by Ashvin Devasundaram, Queen Mary University of London)

Ritwik Ghatak Season Introduction:

A River Called Ritwik

Tue 2 Jun 18:15

The Pathetic Fallacy Ajantrik

Tue 2 Jun 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Sun 21 Jun 18:30

Incomplete Works

Wed 3 Jun 17:50 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Sat 20 Jun 18:10

Reason, Debate and a Story

Jukti Takko Aar Gappo

Wed 3 Jun 20:25 (+ intro by season curator Sanghita Sen); Tue 30 Jun 20:40

The Traveller Musafir

Sat 6 Jun 20:10; Sun 14 Jun 18:00

Shorts and Documentaries

Sun 7 Jun 12:30; Mon 22 Jun 18:30

The Uprooted Chinnamul

Mon 8 Jun 20:35; Sat 20 Jun 12:15

Subarnarekha The Golden Line

Wed 10 Jun 20:25; Sun 28 Jun 12:00

(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Cloud-Capped Star Meghe Dhaka Tara

Thu 11 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Manishita Dass, author of *BFI Film Classic: The Cloud-Capped Star*); Sat 27 Jun 14:40

A River Called Titas Titash Ekti Nadir Naam

Sat 13 Jun 14:20 (+ intro by Tanjil Rashid, Culture Editor at the *New Statesman*); Sun 28 Jun 14:50

E-Flat Komol Gandhar

Sat 13 Jun 20:20; Sat 27 Jun 17:30

(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Runaway Bari Theke Paliye

Wed 17 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Agni Lahiri, film protagonist's son and producer's grandson); Sat 27 Jun 12:10

The Diamond Butterfly Heerer Prajapati

Sun 21 Jun 15:15; Sun 28 Jun 18:15

In partnership with



On the birth centenary of Ritwik Ghatak, NFDC-NFAI carried out unprecedented digital preservation of his entire filmography including feature length films, numerous shorts, documentaries and unfinished works, all under the National Film Heritage Mission. The eight features have been restored in 4K from various film elements preserved by NFDC-NFAI and West Bengal State Film Archive, with colour grading supervised by renowned Indian cinematographer Avik Mukhopadhyay.

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Peter Wollen on Ritwik Ghatak

There are three reasons why I think Ghatak's work is especially valuable. First, there is the mixture of the personal and the political. Ghatak was a committed Marxist who began his career working in a political theatre company. But his work is always marked by elements of his own life, culminating in his final film *Jukti Takko Aar Gappo*, which is virtually a self-portrait, depicting his own problems with alcoholism. Ghatak wanted to combine insights from Marxism with elements from Indian thought, as well as the work of Jung, with which he became fascinated. All his political thinking is refracted in the films through personal dramas, which bear the stamp of his preoccupation with politics as about individual people rather than abstractions. 'Film is basically a matter of personal statement. All arts are in the final analysis. And film seems to be an art.'

Secondly, Ghatak always wanted to combine the global with the local. He was quite at home talking about Eisenstein or Brecht, Shakespeare or Godard, but at the same time he was completely rooted in the specificity of Bengal, its history, literature and culture. This global vision allows him to see foreign artists through Indian eyes and vice versa. He reveres Tagore as the great modern writer of Bengal, but looks at him disrespectfully. His Tagore is not a mystic or a romantic, but a rogue, a performing monkey, a user of four-letter words.

When Ghatak made a film about the Partition of Bengal, about which he cared deeply, he was unsparingly honest, undeflected by nationalism in his vision of his nation. As he himself put it, talking about his film *Subarnarekha*, 'Refugee? Who is not a refugee?' Within moments he is talking about Brecht's *Threepenny Opera*, pointing out how Brecht invented an abstract London, not in order to escape from the reality of the city, but to create a generalised framework which could be relevant to audiences in many different places. So, Ghatak's Bengal is also an invented framework, a device, yet a device which, he hopes, will enable him to show more of the truth than simple realism could.

Finally, Ghatak tried to find a way between popular melodrama and the avant-garde. He remained committed to a popular cinema, a cinema of the slums and the villages, and returned again and again to the ways in which melodrama is rooted in Indian popular culture. It should not be despised, despite Bombay talkies, any more than Mizoguchi despised the melodrama he took from the Kabuki theatre. Here too, Ghatak made use of Jung in looking for ways of introducing psychoanalytic concepts, 'unconscious' motifs and images in order to affect the audience at a deeper, less conscious level.

At the same time, Ghatak believed in the need for an 'experimental cinema'. He was interested in the work of Norman MacLaren, the Surrealists, Godard. He did not see any contradiction between these two approaches. On the contrary, he seemed to think that popular art and literature were themselves full of devices which experimentalists were trying to recapture, as if 'intellectual montage' or 'dream time' were implicit in folk fables and jokes. Experimentalism was both a quest for the new and a rediscovery.

Ghatak saw himself as trying with each film to find a new form to say something new – now picaresque, now documentary, now epic, now experimental, now melodrama. Each film has something to tell us, something from which we too can learn. 'It is the nuances I am after, the elusive, fleeting nuances,' he said.

Peter Wollen, *Sight and Sound*, September 1991

Programme notes and credits compiled by Sight and Sound and the BFI Documentation Unit

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